

Introduction to Government & Politics

Introduction

Government and politics shape how societies function, make decisions, and solve problems. Understanding how governments are structured and how citizens participate is essential to being an informed member of society.

Main Themes

Structure of government
Political systems and ideologies
Rights and responsibilities of citizens
Elections and political participation

1. Foundations of Government

Why Governments Exist

Governments are created to:

- Maintain order
- Protect citizens
- Provide public services
- Create and enforce laws
- Promote economic stability

Social Contract Theory

Citizens agree to follow laws, and the government agrees to protect their rights.

Key Principle

The government derives its power from the consent of the governed.

2. Types of Government

Democracy

Citizens participate in government through voting.

Examples:

- United States
- Canada

Monarchy

Power is held by a king or queen.

Example:

- United Kingdom

Dictatorship

One leader holds most or all political power.

Oligarchy

A small group controls the government.

3. The U.S. Constitution

The Supreme Law of the Land

Written in 1787, the Constitution establishes:

- Structure of government
- Powers of government

- Rights of citizens

Major Principles

- Popular Sovereignty
- Federalism
- Separation of Powers
- Checks and Balances
- Limited Government

4. The Three Branches of Government

Legislative Branch

Main Role

Makes laws

Includes

- Senate
- House of Representatives

Powers

- Pass laws
 - Declare war
 - Approve budgets
 - Impeach officials
-

Executive Branch

Main Role

Enforces laws

Includes

- President
- Vice President
- Cabinet

Powers

- Sign or veto bills
 - Conduct foreign policy
 - Lead the military
 - Appoint officials
-

Judicial Branch

Main Role

Interprets laws

Includes

- Supreme Court
- Federal Courts

Powers

- Judicial review
- Resolve legal disputes
- Determine constitutionality

5. Checks and Balances

Preventing Too Much Power

Legislative Checks Executive

- Can override vetoes
- Can impeach the President

Executive Checks Legislative

- Can veto bills

Judicial Checks Both

- Can declare actions unconstitutional

Result

No branch becomes too powerful.

6. Federalism

Sharing Power

Federalism divides power between:

National Government

Handles:

- Defense
- Currency
- Foreign affairs

State Governments

Handle:

- Education
- Driver's licenses
- Local elections

Importance

Allows the government to address issues at multiple levels.

7. Political Parties

What Are Political Parties?

Organizations that:

- Recruit candidates
- Develop policy positions
- Organize campaigns
- Mobilize voters

Functions

- Inform voters
- Simplify political choices
- Help government operate efficiently

Comparative Summary

Concept	Purpose	Why It Matters
Constitution	Establishes government	Protects rights
Legislative Branch	Makes laws	Represents citizens
Executive Branch	Enforces laws	Carries out policy
Judicial Branch	Interprets laws	Ensures constitutionality
Federalism	Shares power	Balances national and state authority
Elections	Choose leaders	Gives citizens a voice
Political Parties	Organize politics	Connect voters and candidates

Essential Questions

1. Why do governments exist?
2. How does the Constitution limit government power?
3. How do the three branches interact?
4. Why are checks and balances important?
5. How can citizens influence government decisions?
6. What role do political parties play in democracy?
7. How does federalism divide power?

Summary

The government exists to maintain order, protect rights, and serve the public. The Constitution creates a system of limited government through federalism, separation of powers, and checks and balances. Citizens play a vital role through voting, civic participation, and holding leaders accountable. Understanding these concepts helps explain how political systems function and how people can influence them.

Works Cited

National Archives and Records Administration. "The Constitution of the United States." *National Archives*, <https://www.archives.gov/founding-docs/constitution>. Accessed 1 June 2026.

National Archives and Records Administration. "The Bill of Rights: A Transcription." *National Archives*, <https://www.archives.gov/founding-docs/bill-of-rights-transcript>. Accessed 1 June 2026.

United States House of Representatives. "Branches of Government." *House.gov*, <https://www.house.gov/the-house-explained/branches-of-government>. Accessed 1 June 2026.

United States Senate. "Senate and the Constitution." *Senate.gov*, <https://www.senate.gov/about/origins-foundations/senate-and-constitution.htm>. Accessed 1 June 2026.

Supreme Court of the United States. "About the Court." *Supremecourt.gov*, <https://www.supremecourt.gov/about/>. Accessed 1 June 2026.

iCivics. "Government and Civic Education Resources." *iCivics*, <https://www.icivics.org>. Accessed 1 June 2026.

Center for Civic Education. *We the People: The Citizen and the Constitution*. Center for Civic Education, 2023.

Magleby, David B., et al. *Government by the People*. 27th ed., Pearson, 2024.

Edwards, George C., Martin P. Wattenberg, and Robert L. Lineberry. *Government in America: People, Politics, and Policy*. 20th ed., Pearson, 2024.

Wilson, James Q., and John J. Dilulio Jr. *American Government: Institutions and Policies*. 17th ed., Cengage Learning, 2023.